

IH08

Medieval Art, Architecture, Literature, Painting, Music; Bhakti & Sufi Movements

1-2 questions a paper, but the Bhakti-Sufi block is the most repeated medieval theme in the exam. Chishti and Suhrawardi centres came in 2016 and again in 2023; acharya-to-school of Vedanta in 2018 and 2024; the Varkari sampradaya in 2024. Architecture and painting rotate in as chronology or 'NOT correctly matched'.

Everything the medieval centuries made - buildings, pictures, ragas, poems - plus the two great devotional movements. RPSC asks almost all of it as matching: monument to builder, painter to title, saint to school, silsila to dargah. Get the pairs right and the chapter is easy marks.

Medieval Art, Culture, Bhakti and Sufism

Sultanate architecture

- Quwwat-ul-Islam 1192-98, Aibak
- Qutb Minar - Aibak to Iltutmish
- Sultan Ghori 1231 - first mausoleum
- Alai Darwaza 1311 - true arch & dome
- Tughlaqabad - battered walls

Provincial & Deccan

- Adina Masjid, Pandua (Bengal)
- Atala Masjid, Jaunpur (Sharqi)
- Hindola & Jahaz Mahal, Mandu
- Sidi Saiyyed jali, Ahmedabad
- Gol Gumbaz, Bijapur; Char Minar 1591

Mughal architecture

- Humayun's tomb 1565-72 - first charbagh tomb
- Fatehpur Sikri 1571
- Itmad-ud-Daulah 1622-28
- first all-marble, pietra dura
- Taj Mahal 1632-53 - Ustad Ahmad Lahauri
- Red Fort & Jama Masjid, Delhi

Painting

- Mir Sayyid Ali & Abd-us-Samad (Humayun)
- Hamzanama, Daswanth, Basawan (Akbar)
- Ustad Mansur, Abul Hasan (Jahangir)
- Deccani - Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda
- Pahari - Basohli, Guler, Kangra

Music & literature

- Amir Khusrau - qawwali, tarana, sitar
- Man Singh Tomar - dhrupad, Man Kautuhal
- Tansen - Rewa, then Akbar
- Padmavat (Jayasi), Surr-i-Akbar (Dara)
- Akbarnama, Padshahnama, Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh

Bhakti - south

- Alvars 12 (Vishnu), Nayanars 63 (Shiva)
- Ramana - Vishishtadvaita
- Madhva - Dvaita, Udupi
- Nimbarka - Dvaitadvaita
- Vallabha - Shuddhadvaita, Pushtimarg

Bhakti - north, west, east

- Ramananda - first in the vernacular
- Kabir (Bijak), Nanak, Raidas - nirguna
- Surdas, Tulsidas, Mirabai - saguna
- Varkari - Vitthala, Tukaram
- Chaitanya - Gaudiya; Basavanna - Lingayat

Sufism

- Chishti - Ajmer, Delhi, Ajodhan, Gulbarga
- Suhrawardi - Multan, state patronage
- Qadiri - Miyan Mir, Lahore
- Naqshbandi - Sirhindi, Wahdat-ul-Shuhud
- khangah, sama, zikr, urs, pir, murid

How this chapter is asked - read this before the facts

This chapter has no argument in it for RPSC. It has pairs. Monument and builder. Painter and title. Saint and sect. Silsila and dargah. So do not read it as history - build the pairs, and check that you can go both ways: given Ajmer, say Moinuddin Chishti; given Moinuddin Chishti, say Ajmer.

- Four question shapes cover almost everything here: straight one-liner, match-the-following, 'which is NOT correctly matched', and chronological ordering of monuments.
- The ordering question uses a fixed set - Quwwat-ul-Islam 1192-98, Alai Darwaza 1311, Tughlaqabad 1321-25, Gol Gumbaz 1656.
- Bhakti and Sufism together yield more questions than architecture and painting put together.
- Anything with the word 'first' attached is a target - first mosque, first mausoleum, first true arch, first garden tomb, first all-marble building.

The architectural spine of the medieval period



YAAD RAKHO

Five 'firsts' in one line: first mosque Quwwat-ul-Islam, first mausoleum Sultan Ghari, first true arch and dome Alai Darwaza, first garden tomb Humayun's tomb, first all-marble building Itmad-ud-Daulah.

Sultanate architecture - phase by phase

Indo-Islamic architecture is the name for what follows - Islamic plan and purpose executed by Indian hands. The first Turkish builders had no masons of their own, so they used Indian craftsmen and Indian temple material. That is why the earliest buildings look Islamic in plan and Indian in surface. The technical story of the next century is one thing only - the move from the corbelled arch, which is Indian, to the true arch and dome, which is Islamic.

- Quwwat-ul-Islam Masjid, Delhi, 1192-98, by Qutbuddin Aibak - the first mosque of the Delhi Sultanate, raised on the plinth of demolished temples.
- Qutb Minar - begun by Aibak, completed by Iltutmish; the topmost storey was repaired by Firoz Shah Tughlaq after lightning damage. Dedicated to the Sufi Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki.
- Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer - Aibak's second great mosque, the Rajasthan link in this list.
- Sultan Ghari, 1231 - built by Iltutmish for his son Nasiruddin Mahmud; regarded as the first Islamic mausoleum in India.
- Alai Darwaza, 1311, added by Alauddin Khalji to the Qutb complex - the first Indian building to use the true arch and the true dome. He also began the Alai Minar and built Siri, the second city of Delhi, and the Hauz Khas tank.
- Tughlaq style: battered (sloping) walls, grey rubble and local stone, arch-and-lintel used together, almost no ornament, a fortress look. Tughlaqabad (Ghiyasuddin), Jahanpanah (Muhammad bin Tughlaq), Firoz Shah Kotla and the Hauz Khas madrasa (Firoz Shah).
- Sayyid and Lodi tombs introduce the octagonal tomb with a verandah and the square tomb without one, and the double dome - Lodi Gardens at Delhi is the museum of this phase.
- Remember that Tughlaq work is austere. If a statement says Tughlaq buildings are marked by white marble and rich ornament, it is false - that

description belongs to Shah Jahan.

TRAP

The Quwwat-ul-Islam's arches are corbelled - stones stepped out and then dressed to look like an arch. The true arch, with voussoirs and a keystone, arrives only with the Alai Darwaza in 1311. RPSC has asked exactly this.

Provincial and Deccan styles - one monument per region

When Delhi weakened after Timur's raid, the provincial governors turned into sultans and each built in his own way, mixing the local temple tradition with Islamic form. You need one flagship building per region, because that is exactly how the match question is set.

Provincial styles - monument to place

Monument	Place	Style / kingdom
Adina Masjid	Pandua	Bengal - brick and terracotta, curved 'bangla' roof
Atala Masjid	Jaunpur	Sharqi - giant propylon screen, no minarets
Jahaz Mahal and Hindola Mahal	Mandu	Malwa - Hindola's sloping buttressed walls
Sidi Saiyyed Masjid (the jali)	Ahmedabad	Gujarat - finest stone tracery in India
Gol Gumbaz	Bijapur	Adil Shahi Deccan - whispering gallery
Char Minar	Hyderabad	Qutb Shahi Deccan

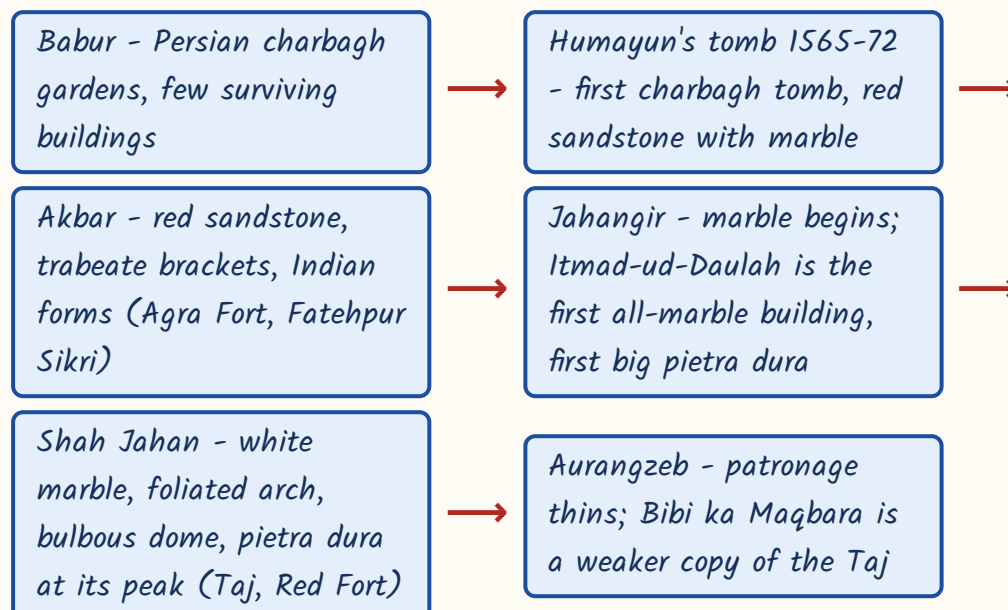
- Gol Gumbaz is the tomb of Muhammad Adil Shah, completed 1656; one of the largest masonry domes in the world, famous for its whispering gallery.
- Char Minar was built in 1591 by Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah of Golconda, at the centre of the new city of Hyderabad.

- Gujarat also gave the Jama Masjid of Ahmedabad and Rani Sipri's mosque; Bengal gave the Chhota Sona and Bara Sona mosques at Gaur.
- Kashmir's mosques were built in wood - the Jama Masjid of Srinagar and the Shah Hamadan mosque.
- Do not file Gol Gumbaz under Mughal. It is Adil Shahi, at Bijapur, finished in the 1650s - contemporary with the Taj Mahal, but a different kingdom and a different aesthetic.

Mughal architecture - emperor by emperor

The Mughal arc is easy to hold because it moves in one direction - from red sandstone to white marble, from carved ornament to inlaid stone. Akbar is sandstone and bracket, Shah Jahan is marble and pietra dura, and Jahangir's reign is the hinge between them.

Materials and manner - the Mughal direction of travel



Who built what

Ruler	Buildings	Note
Babur	Kabuli Bagh mosque (Panipat), Aram Bagh (Agra)	Introduces the formal Persian garden
Humayun	Din Panah, Delhi	His tomb was built after his death by Bega Begum, designed by Mirak Mirza Ghiyas; UNESCO 1993
Akbar	Agra Fort (from 1565), Jahangiri Mahal, Fatehpur Sikri (1571), Buland Darwaza (1601), Lahore Fort	Fatehpur Sikri holds the Panch Mahal, Diwan-i-Khas, Jama Masjid and Salim Chishti's tomb
Jahangir	Akbar's tomb at Sikandra completed; Shalimar Bagh, Srinagar	Itmad-ud-Daulah's tomb (1622-28) was built by Nur Jahan for her father Mirza Ghiyas Beg
Shah Jahan	Taj Mahal (1632-53), Red Fort and Jama Masjid Delhi, Moti Masjid Agra, Shahjahanabad	Chief architect of the Taj: Ustad Ahmad Lahauri. UNESCO 1983
Aurangzeb	Badshahi Mosque Lahore, Moti Masjid inside the Red Fort	Bibi ka Maqbara at Aurangabad was raised by his son Azam Shah

- Salim Chishti's tomb at Fatehpur Sikri is white marble set inside Akbar's red sandstone courtyard - the exception that proves the rule about Akbar's material.
- Pietra dura (parchin kari) is semi-precious stone inlaid into marble - it appears first in a big way at Itmad-ud-Daulah and reaches its height at the Taj.
- The Taj's plan is a charbagh with the tomb at the end rather than the centre - a deliberate break from Humayun's tomb.
- Char-bagh, iwan, pishtaq, bulbous dome, chhatra, jali - the vocabulary the exam uses without defining.

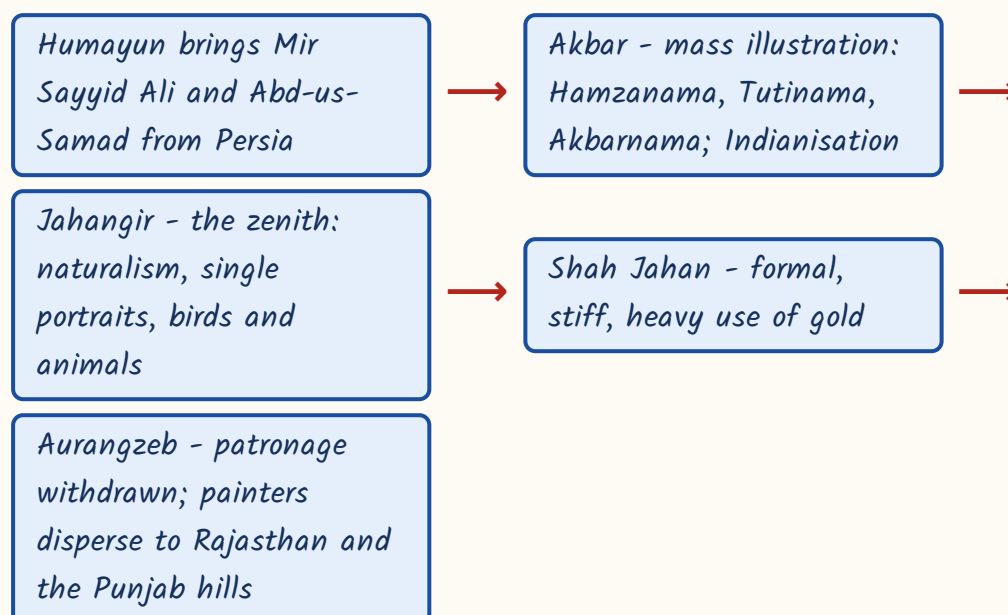
TRAP

The Agra Fort is Akbar's, begun 1565. Shah Jahan only added marble palaces inside it - the Khas Mahal, the Sheesh Mahal and the Moti Masjid. A 'which was NOT built by Shah Jahan' question has used the Agra Fort as the answer. And the Jahangiri Mahal inside it is Akbar's work, not Jahangir's, despite the name.

Painting - the Mughal school and its offshoots

Mughal painting is an imported Persian technique that turned Indian within one generation. Humayun brought the two masters home from Persia; Akbar put them in charge of a workshop of a hundred painters, most of them Indian; and by Jahangir's time the pictures are being made for a connoisseur rather than for a book. Learn the arc reign by reign - that is how the statement questions are built.

Mughal painting, reign by reign



- Akbar's atelier produced the Hamzanama (Dastan-i-Amir Hamza) - about 1,400 large paintings on cloth, the largest project of the workshop.

- Akbar's leading painters: Daswanth, Basawan, Kesu Das, Miskin, Lal, Farrukh Beg.
- Jahangir's: Ustad Mansur, given the title Nadir-ul-Asr ('wonder of the age') for birds and animals - the Siberian crane, the dodo, the turkey cock; Abul Hasan, titled Nadir-uz-Zaman; Bishandas for portraits; Manohar and Govardhan.
- European influence enters under Jahangir - shading, perspective, the halo around the emperor's head.
- Under Aurangzeb the dispersal of artists is what feeds the Rajasthani and Pahari schools - the decline of one school is the birth of the others.
- Say it correctly: Mughal painting peaked under JAHANGIR, not Akbar. Akbar gave it volume and Indian character, Jahangir gave it quality. A statement putting the zenith under Akbar and the decline under Jahangir is false, and it has been set that way.
- Pahari in one sentence - Basohli is the beginning, Kangra is the climax.

The three schools RPSC sets against each other

School	Centres / sub-schools	Marks of style and key names
Mughal	Delhi, Agra, Lahore - the imperial atelier	Realism, portraiture, court and hunt scenes; Mansur, Abul Hasan, Daswanth, Basawan
Deccani	Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda	Older than the Mughal school; rich colour, Persian and Turkish influence; Nujum-al-Ulum from Bijapur
Pahari	Basohli, Guler, Kangra, Chamba, Garhwal, Mandi, Nurpur	Basohli earliest - bold colour, beetle-wing inlay, Rasamanjari for Raja Kripal Pal; Kangra the climax under Raja Sansar Chand - Gita Govinda, Bihari Satsai, Nala-Damayanti
Rajasthani / Rajput	Mewar, Bundi, Kota, Kishangarh, Bikaner, Amber-Jaipur, Marwar	Develops parallel to the Mughal, not out of it - covered in detail in your Rajasthan chapter

TRAP

Two titles, two men, and the exam swaps them. Ustad Mansur = Nadir-ul-Asr, the painter of birds and animals. Abul Hasan = Nadir-uz-Zaman. Both are Jahangir's.

Music and literature - Khusrau, Tansen and the chroniclers

Medieval music questions come from a very small list, and Amir Khusrau is half of it. He was a court poet under several sultans and the devoted disciple of Nizamuddin Auliya - which is why he sits in both the music answer and the Sufi answer.

- Amir Khusrau (1253-1325), called Tuti-i-Hind, the 'parrot of India'; murid of Nizamuddin Auliya, buried beside him at the Nizamuddin dargah, Delhi.
- Tradition credits him with the qawwali, the tarana, the khayal form, and with reworking the veena into the sitar. He wrote in Persian and in Hindavi.
- Raja Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior is the great medieval patron of dhrupad; the treatise Man Kautuhal is associated with his court.
- Tansen, born Ramtanu Pandey, served Raja Ramchandra of Rewa before Akbar summoned him; one of the navaratnas; the ragas Miyan ki Malhar and Miyan ki Todi are his; he is buried at Gwalior.
- Sultan Hussain Shah Sharqi of Jaunpur is associated with the development of khayal; Sharngadeva's Sangita Ratnakara remains the text both Hindustani and Carnatic traditions accept.
- Purandaradasa of Karnataka is called the Pitamaha (grandfather) of Carnatic music.
- Aurangzeb withdrew patronage from music as from painting.

Persian chronicles - work to author

Work	Author	Written under
<i>Tabaqat-i-Nasiri</i>	<i>Minhaj-us-Siraj</i>	<i>Nasiruddin Mahmud</i>
<i>Tarikh-i-Firozshahi</i>	<i>Ziauddin Barani</i>	<i>Firoz Shah Tughlaq</i>
<i>Akbarnama and Ain-i-Akbari</i>	<i>Abul Fazl</i>	<i>Akbar</i>
<i>Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh</i>	<i>Abdul Qadir Badauni</i>	<i>Akbar (written in secret, hostile)</i>
<i>Padshahnama</i>	<i>Abdul Hamid Lahori</i>	<i>Shah Jahan</i>
<i>Muntakhab-ul-Lubab</i>	<i>Khafi Khan</i>	<i>Aurangzeb and after</i>
<i>Humayun-nama</i>	<i>Gulbadan Begum</i>	<i>Akbar's request</i>

Vernacular and devotional literature

Work	Author	Language
<i>Padmavat</i>	<i>Malik Muhammad Jayasi</i>	<i>Awadhi - a Sufi allegory on the siege of Chittor</i>
<i>Ramcharitmanas</i>	<i>Tulsidas</i>	<i>Awadhi</i>
<i>Sursagar</i>	<i>Surdas</i>	<i>Brajbhasha</i>
<i>Gita Govinda</i>	<i>Jayadeva</i>	<i>Sanskrit (12th century, the fountainhead of Krishna bhakti verse)</i>
<i>Jnaneshwari</i>	<i>Dnyaneshwar</i>	<i>Marathi - commentary on the Gita</i>
<i>Bijak</i>	<i>Kabir</i>	<i>Sadhukkadi Hindi - Sakhi, Sabad, Ramaini</i>
<i>Vachanas</i>	<i>Basavanna and the Lingayats</i>	<i>Kannada</i>
<i>Padavali</i>	<i>Vidyapati</i>	<i>Maithili</i>

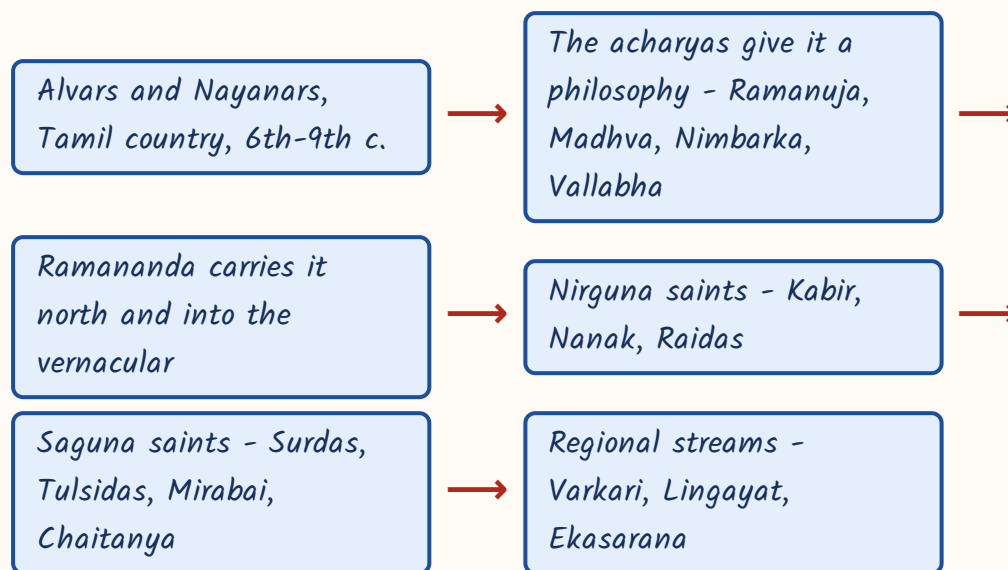
- *Dara Shukoh translated fifty Upanishads into Persian as the Sirr-i-Akbar ('the Greatest Secret') and wrote the Majma-ul-Bahrain ('the Mingling of Two Oceans'), arguing that Vedanta and Sufism say the same thing.*
- *Abul Fazl's Ain-i-Akbari is the third and final volume of the Akbarnama.*
- *Zia Nakhshabi's Tutinama and the Persian Razmnama belong to the same translation movement at Akbar's court.*
- *Watch the regions: Vidyapati is a Maithili poet of Mithila in Bihar, not a Punjabi, and Shankaradeva belongs to Assam, where he founded the*

Ekasarana dharma and the sattra. The saint-to-region NOT-matched question is built from exactly these two.

The Bhakti movement - the idea, then the list

Bhakti means loving devotion to a personal God, offered directly, without a priest in between. That single idea is what makes it socially explosive - if God can be reached by love alone, then caste, ritual, Sanskrit and the temple establishment are all optional. It begins in the Tamil country between the sixth and ninth centuries and travels north over the next six hundred years.

How Bhakti travelled



- Alvars - twelve, devotees of Vishnu; their hymns form the Nalayira Divya Prabandham; Andal is the only woman among them.
- Nayanars - sixty-three, devotees of Shiva; their hymns form the Tevaram. Appar, Sambandar and Sundarar are the best known.
- Nirguna bhakti worships God without form or attribute - Kabir, Nanak, Raidas, Dadu.
- Saguna bhakti worships God in a form, usually Rama or Krishna - Tulsidas, Surdas, Mirabai, Chaitanya.

- The saints wrote in the people's languages, and that is the movement's lasting effect - Marathi abhanga, Hindi doha, Kannada vachana, Bengali padavali all come out of it.

The acharyas - founder, philosophy, sampradaya

Acharya	School of Vedanta	Sampradaya / centre
Ramanuja	Vishishtadvaita - qualified non-dualism	Sri sampradaya; Srirangam
Madhvacharya (Ananda Tirtha)	Dvaita / Tattvavada - dualism	Brahma sampradaya; Udupi, the Ashta Mathas
Nimbarka	Dvaitadvaita - dualistic non-dualism	Sanaka sampradaya; Radha-Krishna worship
Vallabhacharya	Shuddhadvaita - pure non-dualism	Rudra sampradaya, Pushtimarg; Nathdwara in Rajasthan

Saint to sect to region - the north, west and east

Saint	Sect / stream	Region
Ramananda	Ramanandi; first to preach bhakti in the vernacular in the north	Varanasi
Kabir	Nirguna; Kabirpanth; verses in the Bijak	Varanasi, died at Maghar
Guru Nanak (b. 1469, Talwandi)	Sikh panth; Adi Granth compiled by Guru Arjan Dev, 1604	Punjab
Raidas (Ravidas)	Nirguna; disciple of Ramananda	Varanasi
Surdas	Pushtimarg; one of the Ashtachhap	Braj
Tulsidas	Rama bhakti; Ramcharitmanas	Awadh
Mirabai	Krishna bhakti	Mewar, Rajasthan
Namdev, Dnyaneshwar, Chokhamela, Eknath, Tukaram	Varkari sampradaya - Vitthala of Pandharpur	Maharashtra
Chaitanya Mahaprabhu (b. 1486, Nabadwip)	Gaudiya Vaishnavism; Achintya Bhedabheda; sankirtan	Bengal and Odisha

Saint	Sect / stream	Region
Basavanna	Lingayat / Virashaiva; Anubhava Mantapa; vachanas	Karnataka
Shankaradeva	Ekasarana dharma; the sattra institution	Assam
Vidyapati	Maithili Vaishnava padavali	Mithila, Bihar

- Ramananda's disciples are asked as a list: Kabir, Raidas, Dhanna, Pipa and Sena - and Dhanna and Pipa are Rajasthan's own, which is why RPSC likes this line.
- The Ashtachhap - eight poets of the Pushtimarg, including Surdas - was constituted not by Vallabhacharya himself but by his son Vitthalnath.
- The Varkari wari, the annual pilgrimage on foot to Pandharpur, culminates on Ashadhi Ekadashi; Chokhamela, a Mahar saint, shows how far the movement cut across caste.
- Basavanna was a minister of the Kalachuri king Bijjala; the Lingayats rejected caste, ritual and image worship.
- Mnemonic for the acharyas - R-M-N-V in that order gives Vishishtadvaita, Dvaita, Dvaitadvaita, Shuddhadvaita: Ramanuja qualified, Madhva pure dualism, Nimbarka both, Vallabha pure.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2018 and again in 2024 - the acharya-to-school match. Ramanuja / Vishishtadvaita, Madhvacharya / Dvaita or Tattvavada, Nimbarka / Dvaitadvaita, Vallabhacharya / Shuddhadvaita. Learn it as a block of four; it is the most reliably repeated item in this chapter.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 as a statement question on the Varkari sampradaya - the devotees worship Vitthala of Pandharpur, the saints include Dnyaneshwar, Namdev and Tukaram, and the wari falls on Ashadhi Ekadashi. All three statements were correct.

Sufism - silsilas, dargahs and the vocabulary

Sufism is Islam's mystical strand. Its goal is fana - the annihilation of the self in God - reached through love, discipline and the guidance of a master. The master is the pir or shaikh, the disciple is the murid, and the chain of masters running back through the generations is the silsila. That word is your whole exam answer: four silsilas, four founders in India, four centres.

Silsila to founder in India to centre

Silsila	Founder / chief figure in India	Centre
Chishti	Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti (Gharib Nawaz)	Ajmer, Rajasthan
Suhrawardi	Shaikh Bahauddin Zakariya	Multan
Qadiri	Miyan Mir (spiritual guide of Dara Shukoh)	Lahore
Naqshbandi	Brought by Khwaja Baqi Billah; its great figure Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi	Delhi, then Sirhind
Firdausi	Shaikh Sharfuddin Yahya Maneri	Bihar

The Chishti chain - saint to dargah

Saint	Seat / dargah
Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti	Ajmer
Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki	Mehrauli, Delhi
Baba Fariduddin Ganj-i-Shakar	Ajodhan (modern Pakpattan)
Nizamuddin Auliya	Delhi

Saint	Seat / dargah
Nasiruddin Chiragh-i-Dehlavi	Delhi
Gesu Daraz (Bandanawaz)	Gulbarga, Deccan
Shaikh Salim Chishti	Fatehpur Sikri

- Chishtis refused state office, land grants and wealth, lived among the poor, and accepted futuh - unasked-for offerings. That is why the order spread widest.
- Suhrawardis did the opposite - they accepted state patronage, offices and property, and stayed close to the sultans.
- Wahdat-ul-Wujud, 'unity of being', is Ibn Arabi's doctrine, widely followed in India. Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi opposed it with Wahdat-ul-Shuhud, 'apparentism', and was titled Mujaddid-i-Alf-i-Sani, the reviver of the second millennium.
- Vocabulary that appears in options: khangah (hospice), dargah (tomb-shrine), sama (devotional music assembly), zikr (remembrance of God's name), urs (death anniversary, celebrated as a union with God), pir and murid, futuh, wilayat (spiritual jurisdiction).
- The Chishtis permitted sama; the Suhrawardis and the orthodox ulema objected to it - qawwali grew out of the Chishti sama.
- Amir Khusrau at the Nizamuddin khangah is the bridge between Sufism and Indian music.
- Mnemonic - four silsilas, four places, in order C-S-Q-N: Chishti-Ajmer, Suhrawardi-Multan, Qadiri-Lahore, Naqshbandi-Sirhind. A-M-L-S.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2016 and again in 2023 - Moinuddin Chishti's dargah is at Ajmer, and Bahauddin Zakariya's Suhrawardi centre was at Multan. Both came back verbatim. Being a Rajasthan exam, expect Ajmer to appear from either this chapter or the fairs-and-festivals chapter.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 set the Chishti saint-to-dargah match - Moinuddin at Ajmer, Baba Farid at Ajodhan, Nizamuddin at Delhi, Gesu Daraz at Gulbarga. And the 'which pair is NOT correctly matched' version has used Miyan Mir, who was Qadiri, labelled as a Chishti.

Bhakti against Sufi - the comparison RPSC keeps returning to

The examiner likes this pair because the two movements look alike from a distance and differ in every detail up close. Both are devotional, both attack ritual and orthodoxy, both use music and the vernacular, and both are led by a teacher who gathers disciples. Then everything else diverges. Fix the differences in a table and you will never mix a term from one into the other.

Bhakti vs Sufism

Bhakti	Sufism
Grew inside Hinduism; roots in the Tamil Alvar and Nayanar hymns of the 6th-9th century.	Grew inside Islam; entered India with the Turks from the late 12th century.
Goal: union with a personal God through prem and bhakti.	Goal: fana, the annihilation of the self in God.
Teacher is the guru; the community is the sampradaya or panth.	Teacher is the pir or shaikh; the chain is the silsila; the disciple is the murid.
Institution: the temple, the math, the satsang.	Institution: the khanqah in life, the dargah after death.
Music: kirtan, bhajan, abhangas, sankirtan.	Music: sama, and the qawwali of the Chishtis.
Split within: nirguna (formless) vs saguna (with form).	Split within: Wahdat-ul-Wujud (Ibn Arabi) vs Wahdat-ul-Shuhud (Sirhindi).
Target of criticism: caste, ritual and the priestly monopoly.	Target of criticism: the legalism of the ulema and the pull of the court.
Language: Tamil, Marathi, Hindi, Braj, Awadhi, Kannada, Bengali.	Language: Persian for theology; Hindavi and local speech for verse and song.

- Where they meet: Kabir drew on both, and both traditions claim him - Hindus and Muslims are said to have disputed his body at Maghar.
- Both made the vernacular respectable and both drew followers across caste and community lines.
- Both worried the establishment - the ulema attacked the Chishtis for sama, the Brahmanical order attacked Kabir and Ramananda for admitting all castes.
- Dara Shukoh's Majma-ul-Bahrain is the formal literary attempt to fuse the two streams.

TRAP

Terms belong to one side or the other, and the exam tests exactly this.

Khanqah, sama, futuh, urs, murid = Sufi. Ashtachhap, sampradaya, abhanga, sankirtan, math = Bhakti. A 2024-style 'which term is NOT associated with Sufism' question had Ashtachhap as its answer - those are the eight Pushtimarg poets.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): India's medieval heritage keeps entering the UNESCO list. The Moidams of Charaideo - the mound-burial system of the Ahom dynasty of Assam, in use from the 13th to the 19th century - were inscribed in July 2024 at the 46th session of the World Heritage Committee, which India hosted at New Delhi. It was India's 43rd World Heritage Site and the first cultural site from the Northeast. The 47th session in July 2025 added the Maratha Military Landscapes, taking the tally to 44.

REVISION RECAP

1. Quwwat-ul-Islam 1192-98 (Aibak) first mosque; Qutb Minar begun Aibak, completed Iltutmish; Sultan Ghori 1231 first Islamic mausoleum.
2. Alai Darwaza 1311 (Alauddin Khalji) - first true arch and true dome in India. Corbelled arches before it.
3. Tughlaq style = battered walls, grey rubble, austerity: Tughlaqabad, Jahanpanah, Firoz Shah Kotla.
4. Provincial flagships: Adina-Pandua (Bengal), Atala-Jaunpur (Sharqi), Hindola & Jahaz Mahal-Mandu (Malwa), Sidi Saiyyed jali-Ahmedabad (Gujarat).
5. Deccan: Gol Gumbaz (Muhammad Adil Shah, Bijapur, 1656, whispering gallery); Char Minar (Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah, Hyderabad, 1591).
6. Humayun's tomb 1565-72 - first charbagh tomb, commissioned by Bega Begum, architect Mirak Mirza Ghiyas, UNESCO 1993.
7. Itmad-ud-Daulah 1622-28, built by Nur Jahan for her father - first all-marble Mughal building, first large pietra dura.

8. Taj Mahal 1632-53, Ustad Ahmad Lahauri, UNESCO 1983. Agra Fort is Akbar's, not Shah Jahan's.
9. Mughal painting: Humayun brings Mir Sayyid Ali and Abd-us-Samad; Hamzanama under Akbar (about 1,400 cloth paintings); zenith under Jahangir; decline under Aurangzeb.
10. Ustad Mansur = Nadir-ul-Asr (birds and animals); Abul Hasan = Nadir-uz-Zaman. Both Jahangir's.
11. Pahari: Basohli earliest (Kripal Pal, Rasamanjari); Kangra at its height under Sansar Chand (Gita Govinda). Deccani = Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda.
12. Amir Khusrau - Tuti-i-Hind, murid of Nizamuddin Auliya, qawwali and tarana and the sitar. Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior - dhrupad, Man Kautuhal. Tansen came from Rewa.
13. Padmavat by Jayasi in Awadhi; Sirr-i-Akbar and Majma-ul-Bahrain by Dara Shukoh; Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh by Badauni; Padshahnama by Abdul Hamid Lahori; Tabaqat-i-Nasiri by Minhaj-us-Siraj; Tarikh-i-Firozshahi by Barani.
14. Alvars 12 (Vishnu, Nalayira Divya Prabandham, Andal the only woman); Nayanars 63 (Shiva, Tevaram).
15. Ramanuja-Vishishtadvaita, Madhva-Dvaita/Tattvavada (Udupi), Nimbarka-Dvaitadvaita, Vallabha-Shuddhadvaita (Pushtimarg, Nathdwara).
16. Ramananda first preached bhakti in the vernacular in the north; disciples Kabir, Raidas, Dhanna, Pipa, Sena.
17. Kabir's Bijak = Sakhi, Sabad, Ramaini; died at Maghar. Nanak born 1469 at Talwandi; Adi Granth compiled by Guru Arjan Dev in 1604.
18. Varkari = Vitthala of Pandharpur, saints Dnyaneshwar, Namdev, Chokhamela, Eknath, Tukaram; Chaitanya = Gaudiya, Achintya Bhedabheda; Basavanna = Lingayat, Anubhava Mantapa.
19. Silsilas: Chishti-Ajmer, Suhrawardi-Multan, Qadiri-Lahore (Miyan Mir), Naqshbandi-Sirhind (Sirhindi, Mujaddid-i-Alf-i-Sani).
20. Chishtis refused state office and permitted sama; Suhrawardis took state patronage. Wahdat-ul-Wujud (Ibn Arabi) vs Wahdat-ul-Shuhud (Sirhindi). Vocabulary: khanqah, dargah, sama, zikr, urs, pir, murid, futuh - and Ashtachhap is Bhakti, not Sufi.